

Claude Skills

Teach Claude your way of working, once.

Created by Hans Tandt · Version 2.0 · September 2026

This guide explains what a skill is, where skills work, how to install and update one, and how to write your own. No programming needed. It takes about fifteen minutes.

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This guide is a snapshot

It reflects Claude as of September 2026. Menu names move quickly. If a screen looks different, trust the app and support.claude.com.

1. Understand what a skill is

A skill is a small zip file with instructions inside. The main file is **SKILL.md**, a plain-text instruction sheet. Sometimes a few helper files come with it.

SKILL.md tells Claude two things: **what** the skill does, and **when** to use it.

You do not switch a skill on for each task. Claude reads the short description of every skill you have enabled. When your request matches, it opens that skill and follows it. Ask for a user manual and the manual skill wakes up. Ask what time it is and nothing happens.

Think of it as a checklist you hand to a good colleague. The colleague still does the thinking. The checklist makes sure the job is done the same way every time.



Why this matters

Without a skill, Claude starts every task from zero, and you explain your way of working again. With a skill, you write your way of working down once, and Claude applies it every time.

2. Know where skills work

Skills are available on every plan: Free, Pro, Max, Team and Enterprise.

Where you work	Which skills it uses
The Claude app (chat and Cowork)	The skills enabled in your account, under Customize → Skills .
Claude Code	Your account skills too, when you sign in with the same Claude account. Plus skills in folders on your PC: <code>~/claude/skills/</code> and <code>.claude/skills/</code> inside a project.
Team or Enterprise account	Only if your organisation allows skills. Admins manage this under Organization settings → Plugins & skills .



One upload, everywhere

Upload a skill once in the app, and it follows you into chat, Cowork and Claude Code. In Claude Code, type `/skills` to see them; synced skills are listed under "claude.ai sync".

3. Install a skill

3.1 Upload it to your account (recommended)

1. Open the Claude app.
2. Go to **Customize**, then **Skills**.
3. Upload the skill's **.zip** file.
4. Check that the skill appears with its name and description.
5. Start a new chat and ask for the thing the skill does.

Success looks like this: Claude uses the skill without you naming it.

Company account

On a Team or Enterprise account, an administrator may first have to allow skills. If uploading is missing or greyed out, ask your administrator.

3.2 Put it in a folder on your PC (Claude Code only)

Use this for a skill you only need in Claude Code, or one you are still testing.

1. Open File Explorer and go to `C:\Users\<your name>\.claude\skills\`. Create the folder if it is not there.
2. Right-click the .zip file and choose **Extract All** into that folder.
3. Check that you now have `...\skills\<skill name>\SKILL.md`.
4. Close and reopen Claude Code.



The folder inside the zip is the skill

If you end up with `skills\my-skill\my-skill\SKILL.md` (the folder twice), Claude Code will not find it. Move the inner folder up one level.

4. Update a skill you already have

A new version does not simply overwrite the old one. Do it in this order.

In the Claude app

1. Open **Customize** → **Skills**.
2. Delete the old skill.
3. Upload the new .zip.

In a folder on your PC

1. If the skill keeps settings of its own on your PC (a profile or config file), copy that file somewhere safe.
2. Delete the whole old skill folder.
3. Extract the new .zip in its place.
4. Put the settings file back.



Do not extract over the top

Extracting merges folders: a file the new version removed stays behind, and you end up with a folder that is neither version. Delete the old folder first.



Check the version

Open SKILL.md and read the version near the top. A copy that failed halfway looks exactly like one that worked.

5. See what good skills look like

Here are four skills I use every day. They show the two kinds of skill: a **method** you ask for, and a **rule** Claude applies by itself.

Skill	What it does	When Claude uses it
Manual builder	Turns a description into a finished Word and PDF manual in one house style, and repairs bad page breaks.	When you ask for a manual, guide or handbook.
Anti-truncation	Writes long files safely, then reopens them to check the end is really there.	By itself, every time it saves or converts a long file.
Verify before done	Tests the real thing (the button, the page, the saved file) before saying a job is finished.	By itself, before it reports a change as done.
Self-improver	Folds what you learned back into a skill, logs the change and re-packs the zip.	When you say "update the skill with what we learned".

A method or a rule?

A **method** skill waits until you ask for that kind of work. A **rule** skill has a description that matches almost everything, so it quietly applies all the time. Both are just a SKILL.md.

6. Make your own

A skill is a folder with a SKILL.md file, zipped. The file starts with a **name** and a **description**, then the instructions. The description is the most important part: Claude reads it to decide when to use the skill.

If the description says...	Then...
"Helps with documents"	Claude cannot tell when to use it. It fires too often, or never.
"Fix page breaks in a Word .docx. Use when a heading sits alone at the foot of a page or a table is cut in two."	Claude knows exactly when. It fires on those words and stays quiet otherwise.

The fastest way to build one: ask Claude. For example: "Make me a skill that writes our weekly report in our format." Then use it, correct it, and ask Claude to fold the corrections back into the skill.



Personal skills are often the best

One for your own tax return. One that writes your out-of-office message in the right languages. Build them with your own data, and keep them private.



Read a skill before you share it

A skill can carry names, numbers and addresses inside its files. Open the zip and read SKILL.md before you give it to anyone.

7. Fix problems

If...	It means...	Then...
Uploading is missing or greyed out	Skills are not allowed on your company account.	Ask your administrator.
The skill is installed but Claude ignores it	Your request did not match its description.	Use the words from the description, or name it: "use the manual skill".
Claude Code does not see a folder skill	Wrong folder, or the folder is nested twice.	Check that ... \.claude\skills\<<name>\SKILL.md exists, then restart Claude Code.
An old version keeps coming back	The old zip was uploaded again, or the old folder is still there.	Check the version in SKILL.md; delete the old one first.
You are not sure which skills Claude Code has	It combines account skills and folder skills.	Type /skills in Claude Code to see the full list.

8. Glossary

Term	In plain words
Skill	A zipped folder of instructions that Claude follows when a request matches its description.
SKILL.md	The instruction file inside a skill: name, description, then the method.
Description	The one or two sentences Claude reads to decide when to use a skill.
Customize → Skills	The place in the Claude app where you upload, enable and delete skills.
Claude Code	The part of Claude that works in your files and runs commands on your PC.
/skills	The Claude Code command that lists every skill it can use.
Method skill / rule skill	A skill you ask for / a skill Claude applies by itself.